

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Avalanche

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stay out of avalanche terrain when conditions are unsafe. Read the local avalanche forecast before travel and choose a safer route; rescue equipment does not make a dangerous slope safe. If someone is buried, call rescue and start companion rescue only where you can avoid another avalanche.

Do now.

**Check conditions before departure**

01

Consult the local avalanche center and get training before entering snow-covered backcountry.

**Choose terrain deliberately**

02

Avoid avalanche paths and slopes identified in the forecast; turn around when uncertain.

**Carry and know rescue gear**

03

Each person needs a transceiver, probe and shovel and practiced companion rescue skills.

**If an avalanche occurs**

04

Note the last seen location, call rescue and assess continuing danger before searching.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Without a working phone, prevention and trained companion rescue are even more important. Stay on terrain you have assessed as safe; do not enter a dangerous slope to find reception. Carry a written route and turnaround time with a trusted contact.

Watch for.

Do not enter unstable terrain for an untrained rescue that may create more victims.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area

Next decision.

Take a practical avalanche course and travel with trained partners. Use professional local advice for route selection.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

[Avalanche · official guidance](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/avalanche/>